

Managing Stress

Take back control when everything speeds up

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Take back control when everything speeds up

Stress isn't the enemy: in small doses, it gets us moving. The problem is when it settles in — constant tension, worsening sleep, feeling overwhelmed. The good news: you can learn to regulate it.

This guide helps you understand your stress, ease the racing mind, and put concrete supports in place to find room to breathe.

Your intention

Your main source of stress right now: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Your relationship to stress

How we handle pressure often comes from far back: having to 'succeed at everything', never stopping, proving our worth through performance. Understanding these drivers means no longer exhausting yourself for demands that may no longer be yours.

Slowing down isn't failing.

Example

Sure he had to 'hold on without ever faltering', Tom ran himself to exhaustion. Recognizing the pattern let him slow down.

Exercise — My drivers

What pushes me to never stop? To whom/what do I believe I must prove something?

What stress protects

Sometimes stress 'fills up' to avoid an emptiness or an emotion. What might it be helping me avoid?

→ *My relationship to stress is learned — I can readjust it.*

The racing mind

Stress feeds on thoughts: 'I'll never manage', 'it all rests on me', 'if I fail, it's a disaster'. These thoughts amplify the threat. Spotting and softening them lowers the pressure.

Focus your energy on what depends on you.

Example

Under the thought 'everything will collapse', Inès listed what actually depended on her. The stress dropped a notch.

Stress journal

At a stress peak, note: the thought · what depends on me / what doesn't · a fairer thought.

The circle of control

Draw 2 columns: what I can control / what I can't. Put your energy in the first.

→ *I don't control everything — and focusing on my part soothes.*

Allowing yourself to breathe

Managing stress also means allowing yourself not to be productive all the time: taking breaks, saying no, resting without guilt. Your wellbeing isn't a reward to be earned.

Resting is part of the work.

Example

Léa brought back a real lunch break, screen-free. Her whole day lightened.

Exercise — My non-negotiable breaks

Choose 1 daily break you protect (lunch, a walk, an off evening).

The right to slow down

A line to tell yourself: e.g. 'I don't have to do everything, or all at once.'

→ *Resting isn't a luxury — it's what lets me keep going.*

Your concrete supports

Stress drops with concrete supports: protected sleep, movement, a lightened mental load (list, prioritize, delegate), and micro-breaks through the day. Acting on the environment matters as much as on the mind.

You don't have to carry it all in your head.

Example

By writing her tasks on paper each morning and keeping 3 as priorities, Sofia stopped feeling overwhelmed.

Exercise — Lighten the load

List everything weighing on you, then: keep 3 priorities, postpone/drop/delegate the rest.

My micro-breaks

Place 2-3 micro-breaks (2 min of breathing) in your day. Schedule them.

→ *List, prioritize, breathe, sleep: supports that lower stress.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Empty your head onto paper each morning, then keep ONLY 3 priorities for the day.
- 4-6 breathing (inhale 4, exhale 6): 1 minute brings the tension down.
- Separate what you control from what you don't — put your energy in the first column.
- Protect your sleep: it's your best anti-stress (screens away in the evening).
- Move a little every day: movement burns off stress hormones.
- Dare to delegate / postpone / say no: you don't have to carry it all.

To fill in

Stress journal

Day	The situation	Level /10	What depends on me

My circle of control

I control	I don't control

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Understand my drivers.

Week 2 — Ease the racing mind.

Week 3 — Allow myself to breathe.

Week 4 — Set up my concrete supports.

Your plan in 3 lines

- My main source of stress:
- The thought I reframe:
- My concrete support (break, sleep, priorities):

TO CLOSE

You can take back control, one support at a time.

One support at a time. You slow down, you breathe.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not a substitute for therapy. If you are going through a hard time, please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.